

Handbook Acknowledgment Tracker

Maintain a dated record showing which handbook version is current, who acknowledged it and when, and what remains open, with refusals documented and annual review scheduled.

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Companion files: Excel workbook, editable Word templates, README.

Employee Handbook Acknowledgment Tracker

A practical kit for US small businesses with 5 to 200 employees and no HR department

1. Introduction: who this kit serves

This kit serves owners and office managers in US small businesses that employ between 5 and 200 people and operate without a dedicated HR department. If you are the person who hands out the handbook, answers questions about time off, updates policies when rules change, and tries to keep signed papers in a folder or scanned PDFs in an email inbox, this kit was built for your daily reality.

In a small business without HR staff, handbook administration usually falls to whoever has capacity. That is often the owner, an office manager, an operations lead, or a bookkeeper who absorbs people-operations tasks. You need a method that is simple enough to run in under an hour per month during quiet periods, and sturdy enough to hold together during hiring surges, policy updates, and disputes.

This guide explains a complete acknowledgment tracking method built on five linked tools: a version register that dates every handbook edition, a per-employee acknowledgment log with coverage formulas, a non-responder chase list, a refusal-documentation procedure with a witnessed refusal form, and an annual review calendar. Together these tools answer three questions at any moment: which handbook version is current, who has acknowledged it, and what remains open.

This is a process tool, not legal advice; confirm e-signature and retention practice with counsel. That sentence appears throughout this kit because it matters. Tracking signatures well supports orderly operations. It does not create legal conclusions on its own. Your counsel advises on what counts as

valid acknowledgment in your state, how long to retain records, and how to handle specific disputes.

What follows is real operational content you can apply this week. Read sections 2 through 5 for background and method, work sections 6 through 10 in order the first time you set up the system, then use sections 11 through 15 as ongoing reference, examples, checklists, answers to common questions, limits, and disclosures.

2. Problem background: why unsigned or unversioned acknowledgments collapse

The core problem this kit addresses is straightforward. When acknowledgments are unsigned, undated, unversioned, or scattered across email threads and paper folders, they lose value exactly when you need them most: during a disagreement about what a person was told and when.

Consider how handbook tracking usually works in a business without HR staff. A handbook is written once, perhaps with outside help, saved as a PDF, and emailed to staff. New hires receive it on day one along with ten other forms. A policy changes months later. The owner sends an email describing the change. Some people reply. Some do not. A year passes. Nobody remembers which version anyone saw. File names such as handbook_final_v2_UPDATED.pdf multiply in a shared drive. Paper receipts sit in a filing cabinet sorted by memory rather than by system.

Three failure patterns repeat across small businesses of this size.

First, the missing signature. A person says they never received a policy. You believe you sent it. Email search shows a message with an attachment, but no reply confirming receipt, no signed receipt, no timestamp tied to the person and the specific version. Without a signed and dated acknowledgment linked to a named version, the exchange becomes one recollection against another.

Second, the version gap. A person signed an acknowledgment two years ago for edition 2022-A. Since then you issued editions 2023-A and 2024-A with revised attendance, leave, and device-use sections. The old signature does not speak to the new language. If your log does not record which version each person acknowledged and on what date, you cannot show who moved forward with each update and who did not.

Third, the re-signing scramble. After a policy update, you ask everyone to re-sign. Some sign quickly. Some are on leave. Some work evenings or weekends and rarely check email. Reminders go out unevenly. Managers remind their own teams in their own words. Weeks pass. Nobody has a single list showing who is done and who is outstanding, so the task drifts until the next urgent matter pushes it aside.

Email, PDF, and paper each add their own weakness. Email proves delivery to an inbox, not reading or understanding, and threads bury attachments. PDFs carry no acknowledgment data by themselves unless paired with a signed receipt. Paper receipts can work but require disciplined filing, and a single misfiled page breaks the chain. None of these methods supplies reliable timestamps linked to person plus version unless you build that linkage deliberately.

The method in this kit builds that linkage deliberately. Every handbook edition gets a dated entry in a version register. Every employee gets a row in an acknowledgment log tied to that edition. Every outstanding item appears on a chase list with dates and follow-up history. Every refusal is documented through a witnessed procedure rather than left as silence. Every year has a review date on a calendar

so updates happen on schedule rather than under pressure.

This approach does not require new software. It uses a spreadsheet workbook and four document templates. It assumes you have basic spreadsheet skills, access to a printer or an e-signature method your counsel has confirmed, and a consistent place to store completed forms.

3. What this kit does and what it does not do

This kit provides an operational tracking system for handbook acknowledgments in small businesses. It contains this guide, a spreadsheet workbook with five sheets, and four document templates in docx-compatible structure described in templates.json. The kit contents are: version register, acknowledgment log with coverage formulas, chase list, refusal form, annual review calendar.

The version register records every handbook edition by version code, effective date, summary of changes, distribution date, and acknowledgment due date. The acknowledgment log records each employee, their start date, the version they received, the date they signed, and whether their record is complete or missing. Coverage formulas count signed, missing, and overdue rows so you see completion at a glance. The chase list isolates only the missing and overdue rows and tracks each follow-up contact. The refusal form documents a witnessed refusal when a person declines to sign. The annual review calendar schedules policy review, update drafting, distribution, and re-acknowledgment windows.

This kit does not draft handbook policies for you. It does not tell you which policies your business needs. It does not determine whether an electronic signature method is valid in your state. It does not set retention periods. It does not resolve disputes. It gives you a reliable record of who acknowledged which version and when, maintained through repeatable steps.

You remain responsible for handbook content, for choosing distribution and signature methods your counsel confirms, and for storing completed records for the retention period your counsel advises. This kit supports those decisions with order and timestamps. It does not replace them.

The audience boundary matters. This kit fits businesses with 5 to 200 employees and no HR department, where one or two administrators manage the whole cycle. Below 5 employees you can track acknowledgments through direct conversation and a simple file, though this kit still works. Above 200 employees or with a dedicated HR team, you likely need a dedicated HR system with automated workflows, role-based access, and audit trails beyond what a spreadsheet kit provides.

4. Method overview: five linked parts

The method has five parts that connect in a loop. Version, distribute, acknowledge, chase, review. Each part feeds the next, and the calendar brings the loop around each year.

Part one is the version register. Every handbook edition receives a unique version code, an effective date, a plain-language change summary, a distribution date, and an acknowledgment due date. Only one version is marked current at a time. Prior versions remain listed for history but are never edited after they are closed. This prevents the common error of editing a past edition in place and losing the record of what people actually signed.

Part two is the per-employee acknowledgment log. Each active employee has one row per current version cycle. Columns record employee identifier, work location or team, hire date, version received, date distributed, date signed, method of signature, and status. Status is formula-driven: signed when a signed date is present, missing when no signed date is present and the due date has not passed, overdue when no signed date is present and the due date has passed. Coverage formulas at the top of the sheet count total active employees, total signed, total missing, total overdue, and percent signed.

Part three is the non-responder chase list. This sheet pulls forward only the missing and overdue rows. Each chase row records the employee, the version outstanding, the due date, each follow-up date, the channel used, who followed up, and the result. The rule is simple: no outstanding acknowledgment sits without a next follow-up date. The chase list is reviewed on a fixed rhythm, usually weekly during an active acknowledgment window and monthly otherwise.

Part four is the refusal-documentation procedure. A refusal is different from silence. Silence means no response yet and stays on the chase list. Refusal means the person was offered the handbook, had a chance to ask questions, and declined to sign the receipt. That event is documented on the refusal form with date, time, location, witnesses, the exact language the person used or a factual summary, and the administrator response. A witnessed refusal note does not force a signature. It creates a factual record that the opportunity to acknowledge was provided and declined.

Part five is the annual review calendar. Once per year, on a date you set in advance, you review handbook content, decide whether an update is needed, draft and approve changes, assign a new version code if changes are made, distribute, collect acknowledgments, chase non-responders, and close the cycle. The calendar also holds mid-year checkpoints for new-hire acknowledgment review and for checking that stored records remain complete and retrievable.

These five parts share identifiers so they link reliably. The version code appears identically in the register, the log, the chase list, and the forms. The employee identifier appears identically in the log, the chase list, and any refusal form. Consistent identifiers plus formula-driven status plus dated follow-up history are what make timestamps reliable. The system works because every entry is dated, every version is named, and every open item has an owner and a next date.

5. Setting up before your first cycle

Before you enter live data, complete a one-time setup that takes most small businesses between two and four hours spread across a week. Do not skip this stage. A rushed setup produces inconsistent identifiers that cause errors for months.

Step one: decide identifiers. Choose a version-code pattern and an employee-identifier pattern and write both down. A workable version pattern is year plus sequence letter, for example 2026-A for the first edition effective in 2026, 2026-B for the second. A workable employee pattern is a zero-padded number such as Employee 001, or department plus number such as OPS-014. Never use nicknames or first-name-only entries. The identifier must be unique and stable across sheets and forms.

Step two: confirm signature and storage practice with counsel. Bring three questions: does our e-signature method count as valid acknowledgment for handbook purposes in our state, how should we store signed receipts and for how long, and how should we document a refusal. Record the answers in plain language and keep them with the version register. Remember this is a process tool, not legal advice; confirm e-signature and retention practice with counsel.

Step three: choose storage locations. Decide where the live workbook lives, where signed receipts live, and where completed refusal forms live. Use one live workbook file per current cycle. Archive prior-cycle workbooks by version code rather than overwriting. Store signed receipts by version code then employee identifier so retrieval takes seconds. Limit edit access to the workbook to one or two administrators. Give managers read access to chase-list excerpts for their teams rather than full edit access.

Step four: populate the roster. Enter every active employee as of today with identifier, team, hire date, and employment status. Mark anyone on extended leave with a leave flag and a return-review date rather than deleting the row. Archive separated employees to a separate section rather than deleting their history. Deletion destroys the very record you are building this system to keep.

Step five: record the current handbook as a version. Even if the handbook has existed for years without version codes, assign the current text a code today, record its effective date as accurately as you can determine from file history or email records, and note any uncertainty in the change-summary field. From this point forward, every change creates a new dated version. Do not backfill signatures you do not have. Mark unknown past acknowledgments as unknown rather than inventing dates.

Step six: set calendar dates. Enter the next annual review date, the next quarterly roster-check date, and the acknowledgment due date for the current version. A common due-date window is 14 calendar days after distribution for office-based staff and 21 calendar days where shift schedules or leave make faster return impractical. Pick windows you can actually enforce through follow-up.

Step seven: test with a small group. Run five rows through the full loop: distribute, collect, log, chase once, close. Confirm formulas calculate, forms print or render correctly, and storage retrieval works. Fix identifier or formula problems now while the data set is small.

6. Operating the version register

The version register is the source of truth for what the handbook said and when. One row per edition. Never edit a closed row except to correct a transcription error, and if you do, note the correction date and reason in the row itself.

Create a new register row whenever handbook language changes in any section that affects employee obligations or rights: attendance, leave, conduct, device use, safety, reporting lines, complaint procedures, or similar. Cosmetic fixes such as correcting a typo that does not change meaning can be logged as a minor revision under the same version code with a dated note, or as a new version if you prefer stricter control. The safer practice for small teams is to create a new version for any distributed change, because it removes all doubt about who saw what.

Each register row contains: version code, effective date, approval date and approver role, distribution date, acknowledgment due date, summary of changes in plain language, number of pages or sections changed, distribution method, location of the master file, and status (draft, current, superseded). Only one row carries status current. When a new version becomes current, change the prior current row to superseded on the same day and record the changeover date.

Write change summaries that a new hire could understand without prior context. Name the sections changed and describe the practical effect. For example: Section 4 attendance: reporting window moved from start-of-shift to 30 minutes before start-of-shift; Section 7 leave: request lead time moved

from 7 days to 14 days for requests over three days. Avoid vague summaries such as updated policies. Vague summaries weaken the register because they do not show what actually changed between versions.

Link the register to distribution. On distribution day, record the distribution date, the method, and where the master file lives. Keep the master file read-only after distribution. If you distribute by email, save the sent message. If you distribute by hand, keep a dated distribution memo. If you use an e-signature tool, save the tool-generated delivery log alongside the register. The register entry plus the saved distribution evidence plus the per-employee signed dates together form the timestamp chain.

Close each version deliberately. When the due date passes and chase activity ends, record actual coverage (signed count over active headcount), the close date, and any remaining open items with their disposition (for example: two employees on extended leave, re-issued on return). Never leave a version open indefinitely. An open version invites confusion about whether follow-up is still expected.

Retain superseded versions and their acknowledgment data for the retention period your counsel advises. Do not delete old versions to save space. Storage is inexpensive. Reconstruction of a deleted version history is not possible.

7. Operating the employee acknowledgment log with coverage formulas

The acknowledgment log is where daily tracking happens. Each active employee has one row for the current version. Columns include employee identifier, team, hire date, employment status, version received, date distributed, date signed, signature method, and status. Status is never typed by hand. It is calculated from dates and the due date recorded in the version register.

The logic is: if date signed is present, status is signed. If date signed is absent and today is on or before the due date, status is missing. If date signed is absent and today is after the due date, status is overdue. Implement this with a formula that references the due-date cell so changing the due date updates every row consistently. The workbook.json file in this kit specifies exact columns, example rows, and formula patterns you can adapt to your spreadsheet program.

Coverage formulas sit at the top of the sheet and update automatically. They count total active rows, signed rows, missing rows, overdue rows, and percent signed. Percent signed equals signed divided by total active. Exclude archived separated employees from these counts. Include employees on leave as active with a leave flag, because their acknowledgment remains outstanding and needs a return-date plan rather than silent exclusion.

Enter data the same day events happen. When you distribute, enter date distributed that day. When a signed receipt arrives, enter date signed that day after verifying that the receipt names the correct version code. A common error is logging a signature against the wrong version because the receipt form still shows the prior version code. Check the version code on every receipt before logging. If a receipt names the wrong version, correct the form and re-issue rather than editing the log to match the error.

Handle new hires inside the same log. A new hire row uses the current version code, a distribution date equal to the hire or orientation date, and a due date equal to distribution plus your new-hire window (many businesses use 7 days). New-hire rows flow onto the chase list by the same missing and

overdue rules, so new hires cannot fall through the gap between orientation and the next bulk cycle.

Handle rehires, transfers, and leave returns explicitly. A rehire gets a new row for the current version with a new distribution date. A transfer keeps the same acknowledgment row but updates the team field with a dated note. A leave return keeps the original row, updates the distribution date if the handbook changed during leave, and sets a new due date tied to the return date. Each of these actions leaves a dated trace rather than an unexplained edit.

Protect formula cells. Lock the status column and the coverage-count cells so daily data entry cannot overwrite them. Review the log weekly during active windows: confirm every distributed row has a date distributed, every signed receipt has a date signed and a stored receipt file, and every missing row has a next follow-up date on the chase list. A five-minute weekly scan prevents most drift.

8. Operating the chase list for non-responders

The chase list exists so no outstanding acknowledgment depends on memory. It contains only employees whose log status is missing or overdue, plus the history of each follow-up attempt. Review it on a fixed cadence and never leave a row without a next follow-up date.

Each chase row contains: employee identifier, team, version outstanding, due date, days outstanding (formula: today minus due date, floored at zero before the due date), first reminder date, most recent follow-up date, follow-up channel, followed up by, response or result, next follow-up date, and escalation stage. Escalation stages stay simple: stage 1 direct reminder to the employee, stage 2 reminder plus manager notification, stage 3 in-person check-in and offer to answer questions, stage 4 documented refusal path if the person declines. Move stages on schedule rather than repeating stage 1 indefinitely.

Follow-up channels should match how your people actually communicate. Office staff may respond to email. Shift, field, or shop-floor staff may need a printed reminder handed at shift start or a brief in-person prompt from their supervisor. Record the actual channel used each time. If email goes unanswered twice, switch channels rather than sending a third identical email. The record of varied, good-faith attempts matters more than the volume of identical messages.

Write follow-up messages that are brief, factual, and consistent. State the handbook version, the due date, where to find the handbook, how to sign, and where to ask questions. Keep one approved reminder text and reuse it so every employee receives the same information. Store that text with the update announcement memo template so future administrators do not improvise diverging explanations.

Set the rhythm in advance. During the first three weeks after a new version distributes, review the chase list weekly. After the due date, review twice weekly until overdue rows clear or convert to documented refusals. Outside active windows, review monthly to catch new-hire rows and leave-return rows. Each review ends with three actions: every row has a next date, every overdue row has an owner, and every completed row is removed from the chase list because its log status flipped to signed.

Escalate with care and documentation. When a manager is notified, log the date and what was asked. When an in-person check-in happens, log who met, when, and what was offered (time to read, answers to questions, assistance with the signature method). If the person then signs, log the signed date and

file the receipt, and the chase row closes. If the person declines, stop chasing and start the refusal-documentation procedure. Continued chasing after a clear decline creates friction without improving the record. Documentation serves better than repetition at that point.

Measure chase performance with two simple counts: days from distribution to 90 percent signed, and number of rows still overdue 14 days past due. Track these per version in the register close-out notes. Over time these counts show whether your due-date windows and channels fit your workforce or need adjustment.

9. Refusal-documentation procedure and the refusal log

A refusal requires a different response than silence. This section explains how to distinguish the two, how to document a refusal with witnesses, and how to log it without improvising.

Silence means the person has not yet responded. Keep silence on the chase list with continued follow-up. Refusal means the person, after being given the handbook, time to review it, and a chance to ask questions, communicates that they will not sign the acknowledgment receipt. That communication can be verbal or written. Either way, treat it as a factual event to be documented promptly, not as a debate to be won on the spot.

When a refusal occurs, follow these steps in order. First, remain neutral. Restate that the signature acknowledges receipt and opportunity to review, not agreement with every policy, using the exact language on your acknowledgment receipt form. Offer time to read further and a chance to ask questions. Second, if the person still declines, complete the refusal documentation form promptly, ideally the same day. Record date, time, location, version code, employee identifier, the names and roles of witnesses present, the exact words used if the person stated a reason or a factual summary if they declined without explanation, what was offered, and the administrator signature. Third, have each witness sign or otherwise confirm the note the same day. Fourth, file the completed refusal form with signed receipts for that version, and log the event on the refusal log sheet with date, version, employee identifier, witness count, and storage location. Fifth, close the chase row for that person and version with disposition documented refusal rather than leaving it open.

Never alter a refusal note after the fact except to correct a factual transcription error, and if you do, date and initial the correction. Never write opinions, motives, or characterizations in the refusal note. Record observable facts: who was present, what was provided, what was said, what was offered, what was declined. Factual notes retain value. Interpretive notes create new problems.

Keep the refusal log separate from the chase list. The chase list tracks open work. The refusal log tracks closed refusal events. Columns include refusal date, employee identifier, version code, location, witness identifiers or roles, summary of stated reason in neutral terms or declined to state, administrator name or role, and file location of the completed form. This separation prevents refusals from being mistaken for ordinary overdue items during weekly reviews.

After documenting, continue normal operations. The person remains employed under the same policies and the same expectations as everyone else. Do not create separate rules for non-signers. Do ensure managers understand that a documented refusal is not permission to disregard policy, and that future policy communications still go to that person on the same schedule as everyone else. Consult counsel on any employment action connected to a refusal. This kit documents the event. It does not advise what action, if any, follows.

Store refusal forms with the same care as signed receipts, for the retention period your counsel advises. Limit access to administrators and counsel. Review refusal patterns at each annual review: repeated refusals concentrated in one team may signal a communication or trust problem worth addressing through clearer explanations and in-person walkthroughs rather than through repeated form delivery alone.

10. Operating the annual review calendar

The annual review calendar turns handbook maintenance from reactive scrambling into a scheduled cycle. It holds five anchors each year plus quarterly checks.

Anchor one is the content review date. Administrators and the owner review the current handbook section by section, note laws or practices that changed, collect manager feedback on unclear sections, and decide whether an update is warranted. Record the review date and the decision (no change, minor clarification, or full new version) even when the decision is no change. A dated no-change decision proves the review happened.

Anchor two is the drafting window. If an update is warranted, draft revised language, have it reviewed, and approve a new version code with a new effective date. Keep drafts separate from the current master until approval. Record approval date and approver role in the register.

Anchor three is distribution day. Distribute the new version by your standard method, record the distribution date in the register, update every active log row to the new version code with the new distribution date, clear prior signed dates into history (never overwrite history in place; archive the prior cycle workbook), and issue the update announcement memo so every person hears the same explanation of what changed and what to do.

Anchor four is the acknowledgment window. This is typically two to three weeks after distribution. Run weekly chase-list reviews during this window. Offer question sessions for teams with substantial changes. Log signed dates daily.

Anchor five is close-out. After the due date plus a short grace period for chase completion, record coverage, close the version cycle for routine purposes, assign return-date plans for anyone on leave, document any refusals, and archive the cycle workbook. Then schedule next year anchors.

Quarterly checks sit between anchors. Each quarter, verify that new hires from the prior quarter have signed rows, that leave returns were re-issued correctly, that stored receipts remain retrievable, and that no register row was edited after closing. Each check takes under 30 minutes once the system is running and prevents small gaps from compounding.

Choose calendar dates that avoid your busiest season. A business with peak winter volume should not set its annual review in December. Pick a quiet month, publish the dates to managers, and protect them. Consistency matters more than the specific month.

11. Worked illustrative examples

The two examples below are labeled illustrative throughout. They use fictional identifiers and simplified dates to show how the sheets connect. They do not describe real people, real businesses, or real disputes. Every number and date here is illustrative only.

Illustrative example one: scheduled update with full re-signing. A business with an illustrative headcount of 24 active employees maintains version 2026-A as current. On an illustrative date of March 3, the owner approves version 2026-B with changes to two sections. The administrator creates register row 2026-B with effective date March 10, distribution date March 10, and due date March 24, and flips 2026-A to superseded effective March 10. Every active log row is updated to version 2026-B with date distributed March 10 and blank date signed. Coverage formulas immediately show 0 signed of 24, 24 missing, 0 overdue, 0 percent signed. The update announcement memo goes out March 10 with handbook location, what changed, how to sign, and the March 24 due date. Weekly chase reviews on March 17 and March 24 show steady progress: illustrative 16 signed by March 17, illustrative 21 signed by March 24. After the due date, three rows are overdue. Follow-up switches to direct supervisor prompts. Two sign on March 27 and March 28. One declines on March 28 after an in-person offer of time and answers. A refusal form is completed March 28 with two witnesses, filed under version 2026-B, and logged on the refusal log. Close-out on April 2 records illustrative 23 signed of 24 active plus 1 documented refusal, with zero rows left without disposition. The cycle workbook is archived as 2026-B closed April 2.

Illustrative example two: new-hire and leave-return handling inside an open cycle. Version 2026-B is current with due date passed and routine coverage complete. On an illustrative date of May 5, two new hires join. Each gets a log row with version 2026-B, date distributed May 5, due date May 12, and signature method recorded on receipt. One signs May 9 and the row flips to signed. The other misses May 12, appears as overdue May 13, receives a direct reminder May 13 and a supervisor prompt May 15, and signs May 16. Separately, an employee on leave since February returns May 20. The handbook changed during leave, so the administrator re-issues version 2026-B with date distributed May 20 and due date May 27, offers time to review, and logs a signed date of May 26. Quarterly check on June 30 verifies both new-hire rows show signed, the return row shows signed, receipts are filed by version then identifier, and no register row was edited after close. Each of these small dated actions prevents the slow accumulation of unknown rows that otherwise surfaces months later.

12. Operational checklists

Use these checklists as written. Copy them into your routine and initial each line as completed.

New version launch checklist: register row created with version code and effective date; change summary written in plain language; approval date and approver role recorded; master file stored read-only with location recorded; distribution date and method recorded; every active log row updated to new version with distribution date; prior signed dates archived, not overwritten; update announcement memo distributed; due date entered and referenced by log formulas; chase-list review dates scheduled; question session offered where changes are substantial.

Weekly chase review checklist: open chase list; confirm every missing and overdue log row appears; confirm every chase row has a next follow-up date; contact all rows due for follow-up; log date, channel, owner, and result same day; escalate rows past stage thresholds; convert signed rows out of the chase list; convert declines to refusal documentation same day; confirm coverage counts moved in the expected direction.

New hire checklist: create log row on hire date with current version; distribute handbook and memo on orientation day; record date distributed; set due date per new-hire window; collect signed receipt

naming correct version; verify version code before logging; file receipt by version then identifier; confirm row shows signed; include row in next quarterly check.

Leave return checklist: confirm which version was current at leave start and which is current at return; if unchanged, confirm original acknowledgment still stands and note return date; if changed, re-issue current version with new distribution and due dates; offer review time; collect and log signature; file receipt.

Annual review checklist, also provided as a document template: confirm review date occurred and decision recorded; collect manager feedback; list sections needing change; draft and approve new version if needed; distribute and collect per launch checklist; close out with coverage counts; archive cycle workbook; schedule next year anchors; verify storage retrievability.

Record-integrity checklist, run quarterly: open register and confirm one current version only; confirm no closed row changed without a dated correction note; sample five log rows and retrieve their stored receipts within two minutes each; confirm refusal log entries each have a filed form; confirm separated employees archived, not deleted; confirm workbook backup exists.

13. Frequently asked questions

How many versions should we keep. Keep every version row and its acknowledgment data for the retention period your counsel advises. Never delete a version to tidy the sheet. Archive closed-cycle workbooks by version code and keep the register as the permanent index.

What if someone says they lost the handbook. Re-issue the current version the same day, record a new distribution date for that person with a note re-issued on request, keep the original distribution date in history, and set a short due date for the re-issued copy. Log the re-issue on the chase list if the signature is still outstanding.

What if someone signs but dates the form incorrectly. Correct the log to the actual receipt date based on when you received it, note the correction with date and reason, and keep the original form as received. Do not ask the person to backdate or forward-date. Record facts as observed.

Can managers collect signatures for their teams. Yes, with controls. Managers can distribute, answer routine questions, and return completed receipts to the administrator the same day. Only the administrator enters dates into the log and files receipts, so the record stays consistent. Train managers to check the version code on every receipt they accept.

What if an employee works remotely or across shifts. Use the same version, the same memo, and the same due-date logic. Adjust the channel: confirmed delivery method plus a live opportunity to ask questions by phone or video. Record the channel actually used. Allow the longer due-date window described in setup where schedules require it, applied consistently to similarly situated people.

What if someone refuses to sign. Follow the refusal procedure in section 9. Document promptly with witnesses, file the form, log the event, close the chase row with that disposition, and consult counsel on any further action. Do not pressure, argue, or create separate rules. Continue including the person in future distributions.

How do we handle e-signatures. Use only a method your counsel has confirmed for this purpose, apply it consistently, save the tool-generated delivery and completion log with the version record, and record the signature method on each log row. This is a process tool, not legal advice; confirm e-signature and

retention practice with counsel before relying on any electronic method.

How long does monthly maintenance take. During quiet months with no new version, most businesses in the 5 to 200 employee range spend under an hour: roster check, new-hire and return review, chase-list scan, and a storage spot-check. During an active re-signing window, plan weekly 30-minute chase reviews plus daily five-minute log entries as receipts arrive.

What if we discover old signatures are missing entirely. Do not invent dates. Record the current version as described in setup, distribute it, collect fresh acknowledgments with real dates, and note in the register that prior-cycle evidence was incomplete as of the date discovered. The system improves from today forward. Backfilled guesses weaken it.

What if the owner is also the administrator. Separate the roles on paper even if one person fills both. Sign register approvals in the owner role and log entries in the administrator role with dates. If a refusal involves the administrator directly, bring in a second witness from outside the direct reporting line where possible.

14. Limitations

This kit tracks acknowledgments. It does not guarantee that any person read, understood, or will follow handbook policies. A signed receipt shows that the person had the opportunity to review a named version on a recorded date through a recorded method. Treat it as an administrative record, not as proof of understanding or future behavior.

This kit does not provide legal advice. It does not determine signature validity, retention periods, or employment actions. Wording in templates uses plain administrative language. Have counsel review the acknowledgment receipt form, the refusal documentation form, and your e-signature and retention practice before first use, and again if you change methods or move states.

This kit assumes consistent administration. If multiple people edit the workbook without identifier discipline, if receipts are logged without checking version codes, or if chase reviews are skipped for months, coverage counts will mislead. The system is only as reliable as the timeliness and accuracy of its entries. Limit edit access, protect formula cells, and keep the review cadence.

This kit fits businesses with 5 to 200 employees and no HR department. It is not designed for larger or regulated environments that require role-based access controls, automated audit trails, or integration with HR systems. Businesses with works councils, union notice rules, or multi-state complexities need advice and systems beyond this kit.

Electronic storage carries its own risks. Back up the workbook and receipt files, control access, and verify retrievability quarterly. A record you cannot retrieve on request has limited operational value regardless of how carefully it was entered.

15. Disclosure section

This kit is an administrative process tool for tracking handbook versions and acknowledgments. It is a process tool, not legal advice; confirm e-signature and retention practice with counsel. Nothing in this guide, workbook, or templates creates an attorney-client relationship, states a legal conclusion about any person or dispute, or promises any outcome in any proceeding.

All worked examples in section 11 are labeled illustrative. Identifiers, dates, headcounts, and timelines there are fictional illustrations of how the sheets connect, not reports of real events or results. Any resemblance to real persons or businesses is not intended.

No outcome promises are made. Consistent acknowledgment tracking supports orderly operations and clearer records. It does not assure any result in a dispute, audit, or employment matter. Your counsel advises on how records of this type are treated in your jurisdiction and under your facts.

Maintain this kit as a living system. Review template language annually with counsel, update version codes with every distributed change, archive rather than delete, and train each new administrator on identifiers, formulas, chase rhythm, refusal procedure, and calendar discipline before handing over edit access. The value of this kit compounds through steady use, not through one-time setup.